

Session 21: Isaac's Birth

Key Takeaways

- The biblical authors use literary design and key linking words to both convey Sarah's joy and echo her doubt at the birth of Yitskhaq.
- As we think about how to approach these stories, the macro view is just as important to consider as the micro view.
- When God's chosen partners behave unjustly, God must work in compromised circumstances to accomplish his purposes with and through these partners.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 21:1-7

A
a 1 **Now, Yahweh visited Sarah,**
b just as he said ,
a' and **Yahweh did for Sarah,**
b' just as he spoke .
a" 2 And **Sarah became pregnant** and **gave birth** to a **son** **for Avraham** **in his old age** ,
b" at the appointed time **that Yahweh had spoken** to him.

B
a 3 And Avraham called the name of **his son** ,
b the one **born for him** ,
b' whom Sarah had **born for him** ,
a' **Yitskhaq** (= " **Laughter** ")
a 4 And Avraham **circumcised** (וימל) **Yitskhaq** **his son** ,
b a **son** of eight days,
c **just as Elohim commanded** him.
b' 5 And Avraham was a **son** of **one hundred years** ,
a' when **Yitskhaq** his **son** was **born for him** .

A'
6 And **Sarah** said,
"Elohim has made **laughter** for me!
Everyone who hears will **laugh** with me!"
7 And she said,
" **Who would have told** (מי מלל) Avraham that Sarah would nurse **sons** ?

But I have **given birth for him** **in his old age**!”

Genesis 21:1-21. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

God’s Promise Fulfilled and Sarah’s Tenuous Belief

The three-step design of this paragraph contrasts Yahweh’s actions and Avraham’s actions with Sarah’s response.

Genesis 21:1-2

A - **God** Acts Upon **Sarah** (Her Name is Repeated 3x)

Genesis 21:3-5

B - **Avraham Acts Upon Yitskhaq**: Giving of a Name and Circumcision

Genesis 21:6-7

A' - **Sarah** Speaks About **God**

Genesis 21:1-7. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Notice the emphasis in each sub-unit on the spoken word of Yahweh that promised the birth of a son, “... just as Yahweh said ... just as Yahweh spoke ... just as *Elohim* commanded.”

This emphasis on Yahweh’s fulfillment of the promise makes us evaluate Sarah’s words in a deeper way. Her question, “Who would have told Avraham that Sarah would nurse sons?” is easily answered: “Yahweh told you both, back in Genesis chapter 18!”

In other words, Sarah’s response is first grateful (“laughter”), but the key word “laugh” reminds us of Avraham’s laughter that demonstrated his lack of trust in Yahweh back in Genesis 17:17.

Genesis 17:17 Instructor’s Translation

And Avraham fell on his face, and he laughed (= *yitskhaq*) and said in his heart, “Will there be a birth for a son of a hundred years?! Or Sarah, a daughter of ninety years, she will give birth?!”

Sarah’s laughter can be understood in two ways.

1. At first her laughter seems to be a celebration of God’s generosity toward her (“*Elohim* has made laughter for me!”).
2. But, like Avraham, laughter can be a response of unbelief, as if she simply can’t believe that this was the work of Yahweh to fulfill the covenant promise. Thus her question, “Who would have told ...” seems to be more than simply rhetorical. The obvious answer to her question is “God told you!” Sarah’s laughter seems to indicate an abiding lack of trust in the promise of God.

Yitskhaq, Circumcision, and Echoes of Noah's Obedience

This unit is riddled with allusions to the flood narrative and to Genesis 17, an earlier Avraham narrative that also echoed the flood narrative. Avraham is obedient to the divine command given in Genesis 17:9-14 that everyone in his family should be circumcised as a sign of God's covenant with them.

God's Promises and Commands Spoken to Noah and Avraham	God's Promises and Commands Fulfilled
God's Promise Spoken to Noah Gen. 6:17-18 "Look, I am going to bring the flood (המבול) of water upon the land ... to ruin all flesh, which has in it the breath of life, from under the skies, everything that is on the land will expire, and I will set up my covenant with you; and you will go into the ark." Gen. 6:20 "Of the birds after their kind, and of the animals after their kind, of every creeping thing of the ground after its kind, two of every kind will go to you ..."	God's Promise Fulfilled Gen. 7:6 And Noah was six hundred years old, and the flood (המבול) of waters came upon the land. Gen. 7:15-16 And they went to Noah, into the ark, two by two, from all flesh in which was the breath of life, and those going, male and female of all flesh, went as Elohim had commanded him.
God's Command Spoken to Noah Gen. 6:14 "Make for yourself an ark of gopher trees ..." Gen. 6:18-19 "And I will set up my covenant with you; and you will go into the ark, you and your sons and your wife, and your sons' wives with you. And of every living thing of all flesh."	God's Command Obeyed Gen. 6:22 And Noah did according to all that Elohim had commanded him , so he did. Gen. 7:5 And Noah did according to all that Yahweh had commanded him .
God's Promise Spoken to Avraham Gen. 17:15-16 "Her name is Sarah . And I will bless her, and also, I will give to you from her a son ." Gen. 17:21 "... Yitskhaq, whom Sarah will birth for you at this appointed time in the year after ."	God's Promise Fulfilled Gen. 21:1-2 Now, Yahweh visited Sarah, just as he said , and Yahweh did for Sarah, just as he spoke . And Sarah became pregnant and gave birth to a son for Avraham in his old age, at the appointed time that Yahweh had spoken to him .
God's Command Spoken to Avraham Gen. 17:10 "This is my covenant that y'all will keep, between me and between y'all, and between your seed after you: circumcise (המול) for yourselves every male."	God's Command Obeyed Gen. 21:3 And Avraham called the name of his son , the one born for him, whom Sarah had birthed for him, Yitskhaq (Laughter).
<i>Echoes of Noah's Obedience. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>	

God's Promises and Commands Spoken to Noah and Avraham

God's Promises and Commands Fulfilled

Gen. 17:19 And Elohim said, "Nonetheless, Sarah your wife will birth for you a son, **and you will call his name 'Yitskhaq'** (Laughter), and I will establish my covenant with him."

Gen. 21:4 **And Avraham circumcised Yitskhaq** his son, a son of eight days, **just as Elohim commanded him**.

Echoes of Noah's Obedience. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

In the flood story, God's promise of a coming flood (*hamabbul* / המבול) was fulfilled, and God commanded Noah to build and board the ark to keep his family and the animals alive. The fulfillment of and the obedience to the divine word are both registered in the narrative.

In Avraham's story, God's promise of a coming son was fulfilled, and God commands Avraham to give his son a specific name and to circumcise (*himmol* / המול) him. Both fulfillments and the obedience to the divine command are registered in the narrative.

In this way, Yitskhaq's arrival and his circumcision strike the note of the flood narrative and mark this unit as a hinge narrative that concludes the thematic cycle and also begins a new thematic cycle.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 21:8-13

⁸ And the child **grew big** (גדל) and he was **weaned** (יגמל),
and Avraham made a **big** (גדול) **feast**,
on the day that **Yitskhaq** (יצחק) was **weaned** (הגמל).

A ⁹ And **Sarah saw** the **son** of Hagar the Egyptian,
the one she **had born for Avraham**,
making **laughter** (מצחק),

B ¹⁰ **and she said to Avraham**,
"Banish this **slave woman** and **her son**,
because he will not inherit, this **son** of this **slave woman**,
along with **my son**, along with **Yitskhaq** (יצחק)!"

A' ¹¹ And the matter was very much **evil in the eyes of Avraham**,
on account of **his son**.

12 **And Elohim said to Avraham,**
 “Don’t let it be **evil in your eyes** ,
 about the **young boy** and about your **slave woman** .
 Everything that Sarah says to you;
 listen to her voice,
 because it’s by **Yitskhaq (יצחק)** that your **seed** will be called.
 13 And also, the **son of the slave woman** ,
I will make him into a nation ,
 because he is your **seed** .”

Genesis 21:1-21. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Rival Wives and the Tree of Knowing Good and Bad

This scene recalls its earlier parallel in Genesis 16, when Avraham and Sarah abuse and oppress Hagar in the first place, resulting in her pregnancy and the birth of Yishmael. But it also recalls Genesis 2-4, specifically the folly of Eve, Adam’s complicity in her folly, and the banishing of the unchosen son.

Seeing and the Eyes

Genesis 21:9 Instructor’s Translation

And Sarah saw (ותרא) ...

Genesis 16:3-4 Instructor’s Translation

And Sarai took (ותקח) Hagar and she gave (ותתן) her to Avram ... and Hagar saw (ותרא) ...

Genesis 3:6 Instructor’s Translation

And the woman saw (ותרא) ... and she took (ותקח) ... and she gave (ותתן) to her husband ...

Genesis 21:11 Instructor’s Translation

And it was bad in the eyes (רע ... בעיני) of Avraham ...

Genesis 16:4 Instructor’s Translation

And [Hagar] saw (ותרא) that she was pregnant and her mistress was cursed in her eyes (בעיניה) ...

Genesis 16:6 Instructor’s Translation

Avram said to Sarai, “... Do to Hagar what is good in your eyes (טוב ... בעיניך)”

Genesis 3:6 Instructor’s Translation

And the woman saw that the tree was good (טוב) for eating and desirable to the eyes (לעינים) ...

Listening and the Voice

Genesis 21:12 Instructor's Translation

Listen to the voice (שמע + בקול) of Sarah ...

Genesis 3:17 Instructor's Translation

Because you listened to the voice (שמע + לקול) of your wife ...

Banishing

Genesis 21:10 Instructor's Translation

Banish (גרש) the slave woman and her son ...

Genesis 3:24 Instructor's Translation

And Yahweh *Elohim* banished (גרש) the human from the garden ...

Genesis 4:14 Instructor's Translation

Look, today you have banished (גרש) me from the face of the ground.

In [Genesis 3](#), the woman does what is good in her eyes and her husband participates. In [Genesis 16](#), Sarah and Avraham do the same. In [Genesis 21](#) however, the situation is more complex, because God has committed himself to the lineage born through Sarah and not through Hagar. He will still bless and provide for Hagar's son, but Yitskhaq is the chosen son.

God acquiesces to Sarah's selfish behavior, telling Avraham to "listen to her voice." In both [Genesis 3](#) and [16](#), the man listening to the voice of his wife is a negative thing. How should it be evaluated here?

Now God commits to both Avraham and Sarah but also to Hagar, based on the divine promise to bless her son as well ([Gen. 16:10](#)). It's as if God knows that Sarah will not tolerate having a rival wife and son around, and, in the interests of protecting Hagar and Yishmael, God allows them to be expelled. The fact that this is immediately followed by God's rescue of Hagar and Yishmael shows that he has their well-being in mind, even if it means a painful separation. This itself finds a certain analogy with the Eden narrative, as God expels the very humans that he wanted to bless. And so even the act of separation includes a hidden promise of blessing that focuses on the seed ([Gen. 3:15](#) and [21:13](#)).

Reflection Question

Sarah demands Avraham send Hagar and Yishmael away, and God tells Avraham to listen to the voice of his wife. What does this episode tell us about Avraham, about Sarah, and about God?